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rather than increase the central intake.

Occasionally, such 'promotee' officers get plum and out-of-turn postings—a senior bureaucrat cites the example of an *ex cadre* officer, i.e., one among those from outside the regular IAS stream, who has been appointed as a representative of the Gujarat government in the national capital. So while the central deputation requests of IAS officers are not granted, such appointments become a cause of heartburn among the cadre civil servants, especially mid-career ones, in Gandhinagar. Currently, only 19 Gujarat-cadre IAS officers are on central deputation, against a sanctioned strength of 68. Defending this low representation, a secretary-level officer reasons that with the kind of attention Prime Minister Modi and home minister Amit Shah have been showering on Gujarat, the state does not need bureaucrats to lobby for its interests. Further, though it isn't spelt out, *ex cadre* appointments may well become the norm, say those in the know. The 14 per cent share such officers have now in IAS postings is thus expected to rise.

WITH ABOUT A DOZEN GUJARAT-CADRE IAS OFFICERS SET TO RETIRE IN 2023, THEIR SHORTAGE—ESPECIALLY IN THE TOP ECHELONS—IS LIKELY TO BECOME EVEN MORE ACUTE BY THE END OF THIS YEAR



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Another reason for the shortage, only whispered about in power circles, is the series of exits of IAS officers after Modi abruptly replaced Keshubhai Patel as the CM in 2001. In a decade starting 2002, nine IAS officers resigned and sought lucrative postings in the private sector. The trend was started by the high-profile officer Sanjay Gupta, who joined Adani Ports in 2002 after quitting the government and went on to become an entrepreneur. Recalling the circumstances of his own departure, one of the former IAS officers told INDIA TODAY: "We met the new CM (Modi) and presented our concerns over the buzz of sudden transfers without consulting the bureaucrats becoming a norm. He assured us that such a thing would not happen, as he valued the bureaucracy. A few minutes later, when I reached office, my transfer orders were on my table... I chose to resign." Modi indeed valued the bureaucracy, but did not appreciate any defiance and operated through a trusted coterie of officers in the CMO, who wielded more power than even most of his ministers. A case in point is senior bureaucrat K. Kailashnathan, who continues to work from a nondescript office next to the buzzing CMO as a chief principal secretary 10 years after his superannuation and is often said to be operating as the 'super CM'.

The senior bureaucrat cited earlier concedes that there is a shortage of secretary-level IAS officers in the secretariat, but insists that the government's efficacy remains intact. "Contrary to how things were done about a decade ago, much of the work is digitised now. It saves a lot of time for the officers; they can now focus primarily on crucial decision-making tasks," he says. Earlier, bureaucrats had a lot of visitors, often redirected from the minister's office. "Now, those visitors are down to a trickle. Also, the ministers' offices are well-staffed with officers who are much more qualified than the ones earlier," says the bureaucrat, while pointing to lateral recruitments. To make up for the missing talent and experience, Modi went for lateral recruitments. He appointed subject experts as OSDs (Officers on Special Duty) in almost every crucial department. In the new dispensation, the CMO has four OSDs, though the other ministries have none. Meanwhile, the younger IAS officers are not complaining. "Vacancies mean our promotions will come quicker," quips a mid-career officer. ■